

Return values and local state

Project: Python readiness portfolio

1. Your mission

Your learning target

I can use a returned value in a later calculation.

I can trace local variables separately for each function call.

I can detect a missing return and test repeated calls.

Remember before reading

Close your notes first. A rough first answer helps us choose the right starting point; it is not a score for your ability.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Functions and arguments. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Loops and trace tables. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Expressions and operator order. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

After trying, check the relevant lesson or ask your teacher. Change the part of your explanation that the evidence shows was wrong.

This week you will practise:

Use a returned value in a later calculation

Trace local variables separately for each function call

Detect a missing return and test repeated calls

Retrieve what you already know

A function `show_remaining(capacity, used)` prints `capacity - used`. What does calling it with `(9, 4)` display? Does defining it alone display that result?

My starting explanation

This week's end goal

Trace return values and local state and explain the changed program before running it.

2. Notice the evidence

Two fictional cupboards have spare spaces. We want to add their spare spaces without copying numbers from the screen. Last week a function printed each answer. This week a function returns its answer so the calling code can store it, combine it or choose to print it.

Assume nonnegative integer counts and used no greater than capacity. This calculation does not validate those assumptions. Work in a Python script so a call does not automatically display its return value as it might in an interactive console.

List the given facts and one fact that is not supplied.

3. See how it works

```
def remaining(capacity, used):  
    spaces = capacity - used  
    return spaces  
  
first = remaining(12, 4)  
second = remaining(10, 7)  
print(first + second)
```

Two calls return two values

Call · Inside this call · Back in the caller

Call: remaining(12, 4)

Inside this call: spaces becomes 8

Back in the caller: first receives 8

Call: remaining(10, 7)

Inside this call: spaces becomes 3

Back in the caller: second receives 3

The caller adds the returned values. Only `print(first + second)` displays 11.

`return spaces` ends the current function call and sends the value of `spaces` back. The assignment `first = remaining(12, 4)` waits for that value and stores 8. The next call stores 3 in `second`. Neither call prints. The final statement prints 11. A statement after an executed `return` in the same call is not reached.

Connect the picture and the explanation

Point to the input, the deciding step and the result in this week's visual. Explain the same step in ordinary words. A picture helps when you can say what each part represents.

4. Compare the cases

Compare a familiar case with a changed case

Using the correct definition, store `a = remaining(8, 3)`, `b = remaining(8, 8)`, `c = remaining(8, 3)`. State `a`, `b` and `c`. In a fresh script, explain why `print(spaces)` outside the function fails.

Keep the procedure fixed. Explain what changed in the inputs and result.

Change one thing in the pictured case

Change: Add `print(result)` after the calls in a fresh script with no global result.

Prediction: `NameError` occurs because that local name is not defined in the caller.

Reason: A returned value and the function's internal name are different things.

5. Words that unlock the idea

Word · Meaning

Word: Return value

Meaning: A value a function sends back to its caller

Word: Caller

Meaning: The code that calls a function

Word: Local variable

Meaning: A name assigned inside a function and used in that function call

Word: Scope

Meaning: The region of code in which a name can be looked up

Word: None

Meaning: A Python value representing no result value in this lesson

Use two terms to explain a step in this week's example.

6. Follow a worked example

Point in execution · Local spaces · Caller values

Point in execution: First call before return

Local spaces: 8

Caller values: first not assigned yet

Point in execution: Second call before return

Local spaces: 3

Caller values: first is still 8

Point in execution: After both calls

Local spaces: Not accessible by this local name

Caller values: first is 8 and second is 3

capacity, used and spaces belong to the current call. The second call gets new parameter values and calculates its own spaces; it does not overwrite first. In a fresh script with no outside variable called spaces, adding `print(spaces)` after the calls raises `NameError`. Use the returned value stored in first or second instead.

Change the calls to `remaining(9, 9)` and `remaining(9, 0)`. What values are stored and what does their sum print? What happens if only the final print statement is removed?

Learn from the worked case

Cover the result before checking it. Say what is given, choose the procedure, and follow one step at a time. Then uncover the result and explain your first mismatch. Ask why a step is allowed, not only what number it produces.

A pictorial worked case: Return values and local state

Return values survive their calls. A function returns a local calculation that the caller stores.

The facts we will use

Python 3: `def extra(a,b): result=a+b; return result`. Then `first=extra(2,5)`; `second=extra(4,1)`; `print(first,second)`.

Return values and local state

Start with the supplied facts

Follow each arrow. Ask which fact allows the next step.



1. Trace first call

Its local result is 7; return assigns 7 to first.



2. Trace second call

Its new local result is 5; return assigns 5 to second.



3. Read caller values

The final print displays 7 5; the second call does not overwrite first.

CHANGE ONE THING

Add `print(result)` after the calls in a fresh script with no global result.

Explain the changed result using the matching lesson.

Read the picture one step at a time

Step · What happens and why

Step: 1. Trace first call

What happens and why: Its local result is 7; return assigns 7 to first.

Step: 2. Trace second call

What happens and why: Its new local result is 5; return assigns 5 to second.

Step: 3. Read caller values

What happens and why: The final print displays 7 5; the second call does not overwrite first.

Match each pictured step to the supplied facts. This is a worked teaching case, not an independent assessment.

Why this result follows

Returning passes a value back to the caller. Local names belong to a function call; storing the returned value creates a separate caller binding.

What this example does not establish

The example uses immutable integers; shared mutable objects require additional reasoning about references.

Read the labelled picture: Trace the two returned values and explain why first stays seven. What happens if the caller tries to print result directly?

Change one thing: Add `print(result)` after the calls in a fresh script with no global result. Predict the result before checking the explanation. What remains the same?

7. Find and repair a mistake

```
def remaining(capacity, used):  
    spaces = capacity - used  
    print(spaces)  
  
answer = remaining(12, 4)  
  
print(answer)
```

This faulty version displays 8 and then None. It reaches the end of its body without a return statement, so the call returns None. Printing 8 inside the function does not make 8 its return value. None is not zero. Trying `answer + 1` raises `TypeError` in this example.

Replace `print(spaces)` inside the function with `return spaces`. Keep `print(answer)` in the caller. The repaired script prints 8 once, and the caller can calculate `answer + 1`. Test the stored value as well as what appears on screen.

Locate the earliest unsupported step

Use the faulty printing version with `answer = remaining(11, 2)`. State the displayed number and the value stored in `answer`. Explain why `print(answer + 1)` fails, then repair the function and predict the repaired output.

State one repair and the checks you would rerun.

8. Practise together

Using the correct worked definition, execute `result = remaining(15, 6)`, then `doubled = result * 2`. State both stored values and what the script displays before a print statement is added.

Change the calls to `remaining(9, 9)` and `remaining(9, 0)`. What values are stored and what does their sum print? What happens if only the final print statement is removed?

Explain your prediction to a partner before comparing results.

Practise with less help: Trace separate calls

Use workbook W2 for the connected example “Return values and local state”. First fill the input and rule boxes. Try the middle steps before asking for a hint. After a hint, try the next step yourself.

Plan · Do · Check

Plan: What is given? Which rule or procedure applies?

Do: Record each intermediate step.

Check: Does the result follow? What remains unknown?

Explain your trace to a partner. Your partner points to one step to check. Swap roles on the next case. Each person writes their own explanation.

Check your reasoning

Use the worked case for Return values and local state. Proposed explanation: “Printing a value returns that value”. Decide whether this explanation is supported. Point to the step or supplied fact that decides; explain your repair if needed.

Answer on your own before discussion. If you are unsure, say which step you need help with.

Explain the picture

Trace the two returned values and explain why first stays seven. What happens if the caller tries to print result directly?

My explanation using a pictured step and the given facts

This is supported practice. Keep the separately named independent case for an attempt before feedback.

9. Run the investigation

Predict, investigate and preserve the evidence

Using the correct definition, store `a = remaining(8, 3)`, `b = remaining(8, 8)`, `c = remaining(8, 3)`. State `a`, `b` and `c`. In a fresh script, explain why `print(spaces)` outside the function fails.

```
def remaining(capacity, used):  
    spaces = capacity - used  
    return spaces  
  
first = remaining(12, 4)  
  
second = remaining(10, 7)
```

```
print(first + second)
```

```
def remaining(capacity, used):  
    spaces = capacity - used  
    print(spaces)  
  
answer = remaining(12, 4)  
print(answer)
```

Record · Your evidence

Record: Given input and fixed rule

Your evidence: _____

Record: Prediction before checking

Your evidence: _____

Record: Actual result, or “not run”

Your evidence: _____

Record: First mismatch and one explanation

Your evidence: _____

Record: Boundary or missing input and expected response

Your evidence: _____

On paper, trace the supplied procedure. If code is provided, predict before running it in a local practice file. Never write an expected answer as though it were an observed run.

Plan → try → check

Before trying: what do I expect, and why? While trying: which step could first go wrong? Afterwards: what did I actually observe, and what should change? Keep “not run” if you only traced the procedure.

10. Build your understanding

Explain → apply → challenge

Using the correct worked definition, execute `result = remaining(15, 6)`, then `doubled = result * 2`. State both stored values and what the script displays before a print statement is added.

Use the faulty printing version with `answer = remaining(11, 2)`. State the displayed number and the value stored in `answer`. Explain why `print(answer + 1)` fails, then repair the function and predict the repaired output.

A function body has `spaces = capacity - used`, then `return spaces`, then `print("done")`, all at the same indentation. What does `answer = remaining(4, 4)` store and display? Explain whether the final print can run.

Explain which evidence supports your conclusion and which claim remains unproved.

11. Connect your project

Add a labelled return values and local state evidence sheet to Python readiness portfolio. Show how you can use a returned value in a later calculation. Use the supplied fictional case and keep its inputs, intermediate steps, calculation or prediction, and limitation. Connect this record to last week's record; a matching answer without a trace is insufficient.

Project evidence · Record

Project evidence: Component and version

Record: _____

Project evidence: Inputs permitted at prediction time

Record: _____

Project evidence: Trace and comparison with earlier work

Record: _____

Project evidence: Failure, limit and human review

Record: _____

Evidence for your project

For Python readiness before the Responsible Plant Classifier, retain a trace of the values, the predicted outputs and the changed-case explanation. Use actual Python 3 results to check the prediction after reasoning first.

12. Show what you know

For a function that only calculates from these integer arguments, repeat the first call after a different call. `remaining(12, 4)`, `remaining(10, 7)`, `remaining(12, 4)` should return 8, 3, 8. Store each result and compare it with a prediction. These examples create fresh local variables each time; do not assume every possible function is independent of earlier calls.

A learner says that a function is correct because it prints 8. Explain how you would check that its caller actually receives 8. Include a second call and say why two passing tests are limited evidence.

A function body has `spaces = capacity - used`, then `return spaces`, then `print("done")`, all at the same indentation. What does `answer = remaining(4, 4)` store and display? Explain whether the final print can run.

My limited claim and a useful next check

13. Study a complete case

Complete evidence record

Two calls return two values

Call · Inside this call · Back in the caller

Call: remaining(12, 4)

Inside this call: spaces becomes 8

Back in the caller: first receives 8

Call: remaining(10, 7)

Inside this call: spaces becomes 3

Back in the caller: second receives 3

The caller adds the returned values. Only `print(first + second)` displays 11.

Follow the input through the stated procedure to its result. Cover the result first, predict it, then explain every intermediate step. The text/table accompanies the figure so the example can be read without colour.

My complete trace of the worked case

14. Try a new case independently

Independent case: Use returns and keep local state local

Trace both calls and the final expression. If `return total` is removed from the function, does this final print complete? Would a separate `print(total)` outside the function have access to its local variable?

```
def twice(n):  
    total = 2 * n  
    return total  
  
first = twice(3)
```

```
second = twice(5)

print(first, second, first + second)
```

My independent explanation, trace and limits

Attempt this case before feedback. Record any help. Earlier examples below are further practice; a case already practised with feedback cannot establish fresh transfer.

Attempt this without hints

Each tray holds 5 counters. Define stock(trays, loose) to return the total using a local variable total. Assume nonnegative integer arguments. Store results for (2, 3), (0, 3) and (2, 0). Print the sum of the first two stored results. Predict that output and all three stored values. Call (2, 3) again to check fresh state.

My independent procedure, result and limitation

Record support used: none, hint or teacher explanation. After feedback, a different case is needed to demonstrate independence.

Use feedback to improve

Attempt the independent case before hints. Record whether you worked alone, used a hint or followed a

model. After feedback, fix the first unsupported step and explain why it changed. A later check uses a changed case, not a copied answer.

15. Your lesson route

Start with this question: Return values survive their calls. A function returns a local calculation that the caller stores.

By the end, I can · How I will show it

By the end, I can: Use a returned value in a later calculation

How I will show it: Explain the deciding step, show a trace or test, and state one limit.

By the end, I can: Trace local variables separately for each function call

How I will show it: Explain the deciding step, show a trace or test, and state one limit.

By the end, I can: Detect a missing return and test repeated calls

How I will show it: Explain the deciding step, show a trace or test, and state one limit.

Remember → watch and explain → try with help → investigate → try independently → keep project evidence. Your teacher may spread this lesson across several classes.

Keep your first prediction. Compare it with what the evidence shows and explain any change.

16. Finish and return

Close your notes. Explain this goal in your own words: Use a returned value in a later calculation

My deciding step, evidence and one remaining question

If you are unsure, return to the worked picture and explain one arrow. If you are ready, change an input or assumption and justify your prediction.

Save your workbook evidence. At the next review, try a different case before opening your old answer.

17. Supported practice, repair and portfolio

Use this supported practice once, in the browser or on paper. Keep the reserved independent assessment for a separate first attempt before teacher feedback.

Return values survive their calls. A function returns a local calculation that the caller stores.

Practice 1: explain the deciding evidence

Which labelled step matches this detail? The final print displays 7 5; the second call does not overwrite first.

1. Read caller values
2. Trace first call
3. Trace second call

My selected conclusion, deciding fact and explanation

Hint if needed: Read the steps in the pictorial case. Match the supplied detail to the stage that performs or records it.

After your attempt, compare with the supported explanation: Read caller values The final print displays 7 5; the second call does not overwrite first. Returning passes a value back to the caller. Local names belong to a function call; storing the returned value creates a separate caller binding.

Practice 2: explain the deciding evidence

Changed-case practice: Add `print(result)` after the calls in a fresh script with no global result. Which conclusion is supported by the supplied facts?

1. We can decide the result without examining the changed input or the procedure.
2. `NameError` occurs because that local name is not defined in the caller.
3. This one example guarantees correct results for every future input.

My selected conclusion, deciding fact and explanation

Hint if needed: Use the changed condition and the deciding step in the pictorial trace. The answer must say what follows from those facts.

After your attempt, compare with the supported explanation: `NameError` occurs because that local name is not defined in the caller. A returned value and the function's internal name are different things.

Repair a missing building block

Review Functions and arguments (python-bridge/8). Goal: Distinguish a function definition from a function call. Short practice: Match every argument to a parameter for the two calls. Why do outputs differ, and what prints when both calls are removed?. Return to this week and explain what you changed.

Review Loops and trace tables (python-bridge/6). Goal: Trace variable values before and after each loop iteration. Short practice: List the four visited values and their running totals. Explain why 5 is absent and what prints for `range(1,1)`.. Return to this week and explain what you changed.

Review Expressions and operator order (python-bridge/3). Goal: Evaluate numeric expressions using Python's grouping rules. Short practice: Trace the operation order in both expressions. Identify which picture step changes with parentheses and predict both results when the multiplier becomes four.. Return to this week and explain what you changed.

Predict, run and debug

The browser lab lets you edit the supported Python examples already included in this lesson. Predict first, run, inspect the actual output or error, change one input, then run again. Keep code, predictions, actual results and a reasoned revision together. On paper, label your result as a trace rather than an execution.

Keep your completed work

Use Download completed work in the hosted lesson to export your answers, reflections, practice feedback and code-run evidence. Open the HTML copy to read or print it. Drafts stay in this browser when storage is available; clear drafts on a shared device.